Incomplete Tribes

Belonging, Conflict, and the Hope of Building a Civilization for Imperfect Humans

“Sometimes it feels as if the only healthy thing left is for people to rebuild tribes around ideals and concepts. Yet we are so limited, so full of needs and impulses, that we quickly come into conflict with those around us. Is there a way out, or will we repeat cycles of peace and war until we destroy ourselves? Do people still hope for a better world, or have they quietly abandoned the ideal?”

This book begins there: not with confidence, but with a question about whether confidence is still intellectually defensible.

Prelude — The Question Beneath the Question

The dangerous question is not whether humanity is good. It is whether a civilization can be built that does not require humanity to become good first.

There is a particular kind of exhaustion that appears when political and technological optimism has been consumed but the human need for meaning remains. One looks at institutions and sees procedural competence without much faith. One looks at online life and sees connection without community. One looks at ideologies and finds, in many of them, either the stale language of twentieth-century battles or the brittle certainty of new factions assembling at high speed. Underneath the noise sits a quieter suspicion: perhaps the large-scale dream has failed. Perhaps human beings are simply too limited to cooperate deeply for long without turning cooperation into exclusion, hierarchy, resentment, or war.

The first temptation is resignation. History can be read as a sequence of formations, expansions, schisms, wars, exhausted settlements, and renewed formations. The names change; the pattern appears familiar. A peace becomes normal, then taken for granted, then fragile. A generation that did not build an institution inherits it without understanding the price paid for it. New grievances appear, sometimes real and sometimes manufactured. A new 'we' is proposed. Eventually someone discovers that solidarity is easier to create against an enemy than around a difficult common project. The old mechanism returns wearing modern clothes.

The second temptation is the opposite: to imagine that tribal attachment itself can be educated away. This hope is noble, but it misunderstands what would have to disappear with tribalism. Human beings do not merely hate in groups. We love in groups, sacri-

fice in groups, build languages and laboratories in groups, raise children in groups, mourn in groups, remember in groups, and turn abstract values into habits because other people around us treat those values as real. The capacity to say 'we' is not a defect accidentally attached to the species. It is one of the central technologies by which the species became capable of projects larger than an individual life.

The argument of this book is therefore neither anti-tribal nor romantic about tribes. It begins from a more uncomfortable premise: we probably cannot have deep human cooperation without bounded groups, and we probably cannot make bounded groups safe by asking their members to become morally universal all the time. The task is architectural. We need forms of belonging that can become strong without becoming total; communities that can demand something from us without claiming everything; ideals that can guide a group without proving that everyone outside the group is corrupt, stupid, impure, or expendable.

I call such formations incomplete tribes. The word tribe is used here deliberately but metaphorically. It does not describe Indigenous political forms, kinship systems, or a particular anthropological stage. It names any bounded community in which identity, loyalty, repeated interaction, shared norms, memory, and common purpose become strong enough to alter behavior. A research laboratory can become tribal in this sense. So can a profession, a religious congregation, an activist network, an open-source project, a military unit, a company, a school, a neighborhood, or a nation. The relevant question is not what the group calls itself. The question is how much of the person it tries to own.

A complete tribe says, implicitly or explicitly: your moral worth, your friends, your information, your enemies, your explanation of history, your future, and perhaps even your private doubts should converge here. An incomplete tribe refuses that completeness. It admits that its knowledge is partial, its jurisdiction limited, its

members multiply affiliated, its norms revisable, and its outsiders not thereby enemies. It can still be demanding. It can ask for courage, discipline, sacrifice, craftsmanship, or fidelity. But it cannot demand metaphysical monopoly.

This distinction matters because the problem is no longer merely philosophical. Modern technology increases both the scale of coordination and the scale of destruction. Nuclear weapons made some forms of geopolitical miscalculation potentially terminal. Biotechnology and artificial intelligence create additional domains in which small numbers of people may acquire capacities once reserved for states. At the same time, digital systems can manufacture communities, enemies, myths, and emotional synchronization faster than previous societies could. The old human animal is acquiring instruments that make its oldest failure modes more consequential.

Yet fatalism is also empirically lazy. Human beings have repeatedly built institutions that constrain violence, broaden cooperation, and allow strangers to coexist without affection. Recent conflict data do not justify a triumphalist story of inevitable progress: wars have intensified again in several regions. But the long record also does not support the claim that war is a fixed annual output of human biology. Conflict varies enormously across periods and institutions. That variation is the space in which civilization exists.

The purpose of the pages that follow is to explore that space. The hope defended here is deliberately smaller than utopia and more ambitious than resignation. It is the hope that imperfect creatures can design relationships among imperfect groups so that no single failure becomes total. Civilization, on this account, is not the abolition of tribes. It is the art of making every tribe incomplete.

Part I — The Problem Of Us

Belong deeply. Rule partially. Leave room for another world.

Chapter 1 — The Animal That Says We

Before we ask how to escape tribalism, we should understand what we would be escaping from.

Human beings are unusually capable of cooperation with non-kin, including strangers. That fact is so familiar that its strangeness is easy to miss. We queue, pay taxes, obey technical standards, submit to peer review, contribute to public goods, follow traffic rules, join organizations, send money to people we have never met, and sometimes risk our lives for people to whom we are not genetically related. A purely individual creature would find much of ordinary civilization unintelligible.

But generalized cooperation is built on psychological machinery that is not itself generalized. We learn norms in particular places, from particular people. We attach significance to accents, rituals, symbols, reputations, uniforms, stories, jokes, credentials, and shared experiences. Social identity research has shown how readily people distinguish an in-group from an out-group; classic minimal-group experiments found favoritism even when the categories separating participants were almost trivial. The important lesson is not that humans are naturally hateful. It is that categorization can become behaviorally meaningful with surprisingly little material content.

This distinction matters. In-group love is not simply the same phenomenon as out-group hate. A group can be intensely cohesive without becoming violent toward outsiders. But cohesion changes the moral landscape. We notice the sacrifices of our own more readily. We interpret ambiguous behavior more charitably when it comes from people we regard as ours. We enforce norms differently. We remember injuries selectively. The group becomes a lens through which evidence acquires emotional weight.

There is an evolutionary literature on what Choi and Bowles called parochial altruism: the uncomfortable possibility that costly generosity toward one's own group and hostility toward outsiders can become linked under conditions of intergroup conflict. The precise evolutionary story remains debated, as it should. But the conceptual warning survives any particular model. The same person can be generous and cruel without experiencing a contradiction if generosity and cruelty are distributed across different moral circles.

This is why calls for humanity simply to 'be less tribal' often fail. They attack the visible pathology while depending on the underlying capacity. A global humanitarian organization needs internal trust. A cosmopolitan university develops status hierarchies and sacred norms. A movement devoted to tolerance can become intolerant of those it defines as intolerant. Even communities organized around skepticism develop authorities, taboos, and reputational economies. Humans do not leave group psychology behind merely because the group's declared values are universal.

The more useful question is therefore how the boundary of 'we' behaves. Is it singular or multiple? Does it move? Can it expand for some purposes and contract for others? Can two people be rivals in one domain and allies in another? Can a member criticize the group without being recoded as an enemy? Can an outsider remain morally legible? These are not sentimental questions. They are structural properties of a social system.

A robust civilization needs both thick and thin relations. Thick relations are the ones in which memory matters, obligations accumulate, reputation has texture, and sacrifice can be asked. Thin relations are the ones that allow strangers to transact, travel, disagree, and remain safe without first becoming friends. Thick relations give life much of its meaning. Thin relations prevent every disagreement from requiring intimacy or conquest. Trouble begins when we expect one layer to perform the work of the other.

A nation cannot be a family without becoming oppressive; it contains too many strangers and too much legitimate disagreement. A family cannot be governed solely like a market without becoming emotionally absurd. A research community cannot function if every claim is treated as an expression of loyalty, but neither can it function without trust that most participants are playing the epistemic game in good faith. Human life is therefore not one social contract. It is a stack of contracts, many of them unwritten, whose boundaries constantly overlap.

The incomplete tribe begins with this layered picture. It does not demand that we overcome the need to belong. It demands that we stop pretending one belonging can safely absorb all the others.

Chapter 2 — The Limits We Bring Into Every Ideal

No political architecture is wiser than its assumptions about the creatures who must live inside it.

The easiest way to destroy an ideal is to design an institution that requires people to embody it continuously. We are inconsistent creatures. We want fairness and advantage, independence and recognition, truth and reassurance, intimacy and privacy, equality and distinction. We are capable of sacrifice, but we also keep accounts. We can admire merit until another person's merit threatens our place. We can defend freedom in the abstract while attempting to control those whose choices wound us personally.

These are not arguments for cynicism. They are arguments against anthropological perfectionism. Institutions that assume selfishness alone become needlessly brutal and leave enormous cooperative capacity unused. Institutions that assume virtue alone become easy prey for ambition, self-deception, and capture. The interesting design space begins when we assume a mixed creature: one capable of loyalty, generosity, shame, reciprocity, envy, vanity, care, cruelty, abstraction, and sincere moral learning, sometimes within the same afternoon.

Status is especially important because it survives economic leveling. Remove one ranking system and another tends to appear. If wealth is compressed, prestige may reorganize around political access, cultural distinction, moral purity, professional credentials, proximity to decision makers, or control of information. The result need not be conspiracy. Hierarchies can emerge simply because people require ways to allocate attention and authority. The mistake is to imagine that abolishing explicit hierarchy abolishes the human appetite for relative position.

The same is true of scarcity. A materially abundant society may eliminate some conflicts while intensifying others. People compete not only for food and shelter but for scarce partners, scarce attention, scarce recognition, scarce roles, scarce locations, and scarce forms of uniqueness. An AI-rich civilization may make competent text, images, software, tutoring, and analysis cheap while making authentic human recognition comparatively more valuable. Abundance changes the object of competition; it does not automatically abolish competition.

Our cognitive limits matter too. Human beings cannot maintain equal emotional concern for billions of people. The popular idea of a fixed 'Dunbar number' around 150 should be treated cautiously: later work has challenged the precision of any single cognitive limit. Still, the broader observation is difficult to dispute. Human relationships are layered. A handful of people can be known intimately; more can be known personally; far more can be recognized only categorically. Moral philosophy can extend obligations far beyond these layers, but emotional life does not scale in the same way.

This gap between moral scope and emotional scope produces a recurring political illusion. We formulate universal principles as if universal emotional solidarity would follow. When it does not, we diagnose hypocrisy. Sometimes hypocrisy is indeed the problem. But often the architecture is asking the wrong faculty to do the work. A stranger does not need to feel like my sibling for me to respect her rights. A distant population does not need to occupy my daily emotional life for institutions to constrain what may be done to it. Thin morality exists precisely because affection is scarce.

Our epistemic limits are equally consequential. Groups accumulate beliefs faster than individuals can personally verify them. We live through chains of trust. We trust instruments, experts, witnesses, institutions, archives, software, and other people. This makes civilization possible, but it also makes social reality vulner-

able to loyalty. Once accepting a claim becomes evidence of belonging, correction becomes expensive. A person may privately notice an error and still defend it publicly because the cost of epistemic dissent has become social exile.

A serious ideal must therefore survive vanity, fatigue, faction, imperfect information, asymmetric power, and changing generations. It must survive the day when its founders are dead, when its rituals become tedious, when a charismatic leader discovers an exploit, when a member falls in love with someone from the rival group, when economic conditions change, and when a cherished belief turns out to be false. Ideals that cannot survive these ordinary events are not institutions. They are moods.

The design question is not how to remove contradiction from the human animal. It is how to prevent contradiction from becoming catastrophe. The incomplete tribe is one answer because it distributes our contradictions across multiple affiliations instead of forcing every conflict into one total identity.

Chapter 3 — Peace Is an Institution

Peace is not what remains when human aggression is absent. It is what exists when aggression, fear, and rivalry have places to go other than war.

It is tempting to speak of peace as humanity's natural state interrupted by outbreaks of violence, or of war as humanity's natural state temporarily suppressed by civilization. Both pictures are too simple. The historical record contains long periods of stability and terrifying episodes of violence, with enormous variation across societies and centuries. That variation tells us something important: whatever our biological dispositions, institutions change outcomes.

Contemporary conflict data offer no warrant for complacency. Global conflict deaths remained far below the catastrophic peaks associated with the world wars for much of the post-Cold War period, but the last decade has seen serious reversals and large wars. The Uppsala Conflict Data Program's recent series documents substantial deaths in interstate, intrastate, non-state, and one-sided violence. There is no smooth escalator carrying humanity upward. Progress, where it exists, is maintained rather than inherited automatically.

The central achievement of peaceful institutions is not consensus. It is conversion. They convert forms of conflict that could become physical into procedures that remain survivable: elections, lawsuits, negotiations, strikes, scientific disputes, markets, arbitration, federal bargaining, professional review, public criticism, regulated competition. Each mechanism allows people to lose something without losing everything. A court can tell me I am wrong without declaring me an enemy. A market can allocate a contract else-

where without requiring a duel. A journal can reject my paper without imprisoning me. These are civilizational technologies of bounded defeat.

This is why the quality of losing matters as much as the quality of winning. A political or social order becomes brittle when every consequential loss threatens identity, livelihood, safety, and future participation at once. If losing an election means losing legal protection, losing a professional disagreement means losing one's career, or leaving a community means losing every friend, then actors become rationally desperate. They will tolerate increasingly extreme tactics because the alternative is total defeat.

Incomplete tribes reduce this coupling. If my professional identity, friendships, family life, local community, spiritual commitments, intellectual interests, and political preferences do not coincide perfectly, then defeat in one domain need not become social death. Cross-cutting membership creates friction against mobilization. The person presented to me as a political enemy may also be my colleague, neighbor, chess partner, cousin, physician, or collaborator on an open-source project. Such overlap does not eliminate conflict. It makes totalization harder.

Contact across groups is not a magical cure, but a large empirical literature finds that intergroup contact often reduces prejudice, especially under supportive conditions. The crucial word is contact, not exposure. Merely seeing caricatures of another group in a feed can intensify hostility. Repeated cooperation in which people become legible as individuals is different. It gives the abstract category a face, a history, and sometimes a debt of gratitude.

Peace therefore needs interfaces. Groups need procedures for trade, intermarriage, shared infrastructure, joint projects, dispute resolution, translation, and emergency coordination. They need neutral or at least mutually tolerable spaces. They need ways to

represent themselves to one another that do not require surrendering their internal identity. A world of groups without interfaces is a map of future front lines.

At the highest technological stakes, these interfaces become existential. Nuclear deterrence, arms control, biosecurity, and the governance of powerful AI systems involve actors who may distrust one another profoundly yet still require channels that reduce catastrophic misunderstanding. The Bulletin of the Atomic Scientists' Doomsday Clock is a metaphor rather than a statistical forecast, but its 2026 setting reflects a genuine concern: technological power can grow faster than institutions of restraint.

The question is therefore not whether conflict can be eliminated. It is whether civilization can keep increasing the number of conflicts that remain nonterminal. Peace is an institution when it makes room for rivalry, anger, and defeat without allowing them to become permission for annihilation.

Chapter 4 — The Fragility of Idealism

People do not abandon ideals only because they stop believing. Often they abandon them because they stop believing that belief can matter.

There is a form of despair that looks like sophistication. It does not announce that a better world is impossible. It merely treats anyone who still speaks seriously about improvement as naive. The mature posture becomes ironic distance: institutions are corrupt, movements become power struggles, revolutions betray themselves, markets manipulate, governments lie, communities exclude, and technologies create new dependencies while claiming to liberate us. Since every alternative can be criticized, detachment feels intellectually safe.

This attitude is understandable. The twentieth century trained many people to distrust grand promises. Projects that spoke in universal language sometimes built coercive systems. National myths justified slaughter. Scientific language was recruited into racism and authoritarian planning. Markets could generate extraordinary prosperity while also concentrating power and externalizing harm. Religion could sustain charity and reconciliation while also legitimizing hierarchy or persecution. The correct lesson, however, is not that ideals are fraudulent. It is that ideals do not immunize institutions against ordinary human failure.

A second source of exhaustion is scale. The individual sees planetary problems and experiences a strange combination of responsibility and impotence. Climate, war, inequality, technological risk, demographic change, institutional decay: each is presented as urgent, and almost none is meaningfully controllable by one person. The moral nervous system is asked to remain activated at global scale. Eventually it protects itself through numbness, entertainment, private ambition, or the cultivation of a manageable life.

There is no shame in the manageable life. The mistake is to think that private retreat and civilizational hope are opposites. Most durable institutions were not built by people who woke each morning emotionally committed to humanity as an abstraction. They were built by people committed to a monastery, a laboratory, a town, a legal practice, a school, a cooperative, a company, a movement, a craft, or a set of people whose faces they knew. Civilization often advances through local concentrations of seriousness.

The challenge is how to recover seriousness without recovering fanaticism. A weak ideal produces no sacrifice. A total ideal consumes the person. Between them lies a neglected category: the bounded ideal. It can be treated as worth years of work without being treated as the exclusive explanation of reality. One may devote oneself to open science while admitting that art, family, religion, enterprise, or local tradition answer different human needs. One may build a community around ecological restraint without requiring every member to share a complete metaphysics.

This is a more demanding form of idealism than purity because it must coexist with ambiguity. The pure believer can explain failure by identifying traitors. The bounded believer must ask whether the institution itself created incentives for failure. The pure believer can treat compromise as contamination. The bounded believer has to distinguish compromise that preserves pluralism from compromise that destroys the purpose of the group. There is no algorithm for this distinction. It requires judgment, memory, and a culture capable of self-criticism.

Perhaps many people have not abandoned hope so much as abandoned the theatrical language in which hope was previously expressed. They no longer expect a final social order. They build smaller things. They choose a profession carefully. They raise children differently. They create tools. They join obscure communities. They fund a cause. They repair a local institution. They write.

They teach. None of these acts looks like the march of history. Together, they may be more credible than the march of history ever was.

The rest of this book takes that possibility seriously. Instead of asking for one world-sized community, it asks how many communities can become places in which ideals are practiced, tested, criticized, and transmitted. The civilizational task is then to prevent those communities from becoming prisons or armies.

Part Ii — The Failure Of Complete Belonging

Belong deeply. Rule partially. Leave room for another world.

Chapter 5 — The Complete Tribe

A tribe becomes dangerous not when it matters deeply, but when nothing is permitted to matter outside it.

A complete tribe is not defined by size. A family can become complete. So can a startup, a church, a political faction, a university department, an online community, or a nation. Completeness is a claim of jurisdiction. The group begins to decide which facts are credible, which relationships are respectable, which emotions are legitimate, which jokes are permitted, which ambitions are admirable, which outsiders can be trusted, and which private doubts signal moral weakness.

The complete tribe offers something psychologically powerful: simplification. Modern life distributes authority across too many systems. One expert tells us what is medically prudent, another what is legally required, another what is economically rational, while friends, family, religion, profession, and politics pull in different directions. A total group resolves the strain. It gives one vocabulary for everything. It turns complexity into loyalty.

This simplification can feel like liberation. Members no longer need to adjudicate every question alone. They inherit trusted sources, moral exemplars, enemies, rituals, and a story that places personal suffering inside a larger narrative. The group can transform loneliness into significance. It can convert an obscure life into a role. For people who have experienced humiliation or invisibility, this is not a trivial benefit. Any theory that treats total belonging as mere stupidity will fail to understand its attraction.

The cost arrives gradually. Because the group provides many goods at once, dissent becomes expensive. To question a doctrine may threaten friendships, employment, romantic relationships, status, and access to meaning simultaneously. The member is no longer evaluating a proposition; the member is evaluating wheth-

er reality is worth social death. Under those conditions, intelligent people can become highly skilled at not seeing what would destabilize the group.

The complete tribe also tends to moralize competition. Ordinary rivalry for resources or status becomes evidence of virtue and vice. If our side loses, someone must have betrayed justice. If an outsider succeeds, the success may be reinterpreted as proof of corruption. Because the group's narrative explains both morality and causality, contrary evidence strengthens the story rather than weakening it. Failure becomes persecution; criticism becomes confirmation of enemy hostility.

Total groups often require a purified memory. Their history becomes a sequence of injuries suffered and virtues displayed. Ambiguous episodes are simplified. Internal victims disappear. Former enemies are denied complexity. This is one reason memory institutions matter: archives, independent scholarship, adversarial journalism, courts, and competing narratives prevent any single community from achieving perfect control over the past.

It would be comforting if complete tribes belonged only to obviously authoritarian settings. They do not. Any group can drift toward completeness when social life becomes sufficiently homogeneous. A professional class that shares schools, neighborhoods, media, political assumptions, and friendship networks may experience its own contingent worldview as simple reality. A counterculture can reproduce the same pattern with different symbols. Completeness is less about ideology than about the collapse of independent reference points.

The first defense is therefore not moderation. It is multiplicity. A person with meaningful ties to several nonidentical communities possesses alternative witnesses. One group can still punish, deceive, or disappoint, but it cannot rewrite the entire world. The member retains somewhere else to stand.

This does not make plural membership comfortable. On the contrary, it introduces tension. That tension is precisely the point. A civilization of incomplete tribes treats some internal contradiction as a safety feature.

Chapter 6 — Universalism Without Warmth

A principle can apply to everyone without asking us to feel the same about everyone.

The moral response to tribal cruelty has often been universalism: equal dignity, equal legal standing, universal rights, impartial rules, humanity before faction. Much of modern civilization depends on these ideas. The difficulty begins when a legal or moral universalism is quietly converted into a psychological theory according to which healthy people should experience the whole species as one emotionally coherent community.

They do not. Nor is it obvious that they could. Human concern has gradients. A parent who treats a stranger's child exactly as her own would not be morally advanced; she would have misunderstood parenthood. Friendship is selective by definition. Love creates asymmetry. Communities exist partly because particular people accept particular obligations toward one another. A world in which no bond could legitimately be thicker than any other would not be universalist. It would be emotionally flat.

The better distinction is between universal moral minima and particular moral maxima. The minimum applies to strangers: do not murder them, enslave them, arbitrarily dispossess them, torture them, or strip them of legal personhood; respect procedures that allow peaceful coexistence; honor certain basic protections even when affection is absent. The maximum belongs to chosen or inherited relationships: care beyond duty, sacrifice, forgiveness, loyalty, shared risk, and forms of generosity that cannot plausibly be universalized at equal intensity.

This distinction prevents two opposite errors. The first is tribal absolutism, which treats outsiders as having no moral claim. The second is compulsory intimacy, which treats differentiated loyalty itself as suspicious. A mature pluralism protects the stranger

without pretending the stranger is already a friend. It allows the family to be partial while forbidding the family from becoming a private state above the law.

Universal institutions work best when they are thin enough to contain disagreement. A constitution need not settle every question of the good life. A court need not make citizens admire one another. A standard for scientific evidence need not determine aesthetic taste. A protocol for internet communication can connect communities with incompatible values. Thinness is sometimes mistaken for moral weakness. Often it is what permits durable coexistence.

There is, however, a danger in excessive thinness. If public life contains only procedures and private consumption, people will search elsewhere for meaning. They may find it in aggressive nationalism, conspiratorial movements, celebrity communities, extremist subcultures, or totalizing workplaces. A society that dissolves every thick association in the name of individual autonomy can accidentally create ideal conditions for predatory tribes.

The task is therefore dual. Protect a universal floor while permitting a plurality of thicker rooms above it. The floor prevents groups from becoming sovereign over basic rights. The rooms give people places in which commitment can become embodied rather than merely declared. Neither level is sufficient alone.

The incomplete tribe belongs on the upper floors. It may be demanding, eccentric, beautiful, ascetic, ambitious, traditional, experimental, spiritual, scientific, local, or transnational. But the stairwell remains open. Other rooms exist. The building is not the tribe.

Chapter 7 — The Lonely Individual and the Synthetic Tribe

When durable communities weaken, the need for belonging does not disappear; it becomes available for capture.

Modern freedom is often described as emancipation from inherited structures: clan, village, church, class, profession, patriarchal household, local custom. Much of that emancipation was real and valuable. Inherited communities could be suffocating, unequal, and impossible to exit. Yet liberation has a shadow. The individual released from binding communities does not become socially self-sufficient. The need for recognition, status, ritual, shared language, and collective purpose survives.

This creates a market for synthetic tribes. They can form around political identity, lifestyle, entertainment, investment, health, technology, fandom, resentment, or a single public figure. Digital platforms reduce the cost of finding people who share an obsession and increase the speed with which a group can develop internal language. What once required geography can now occur in days among strangers distributed across continents.

There is nothing inherently false about an online community. Some of the most productive modern collaborations are digitally mediated. Open-source software, scientific networks, patient groups, artistic communities, and niche intellectual circles can produce genuine reciprocity. The problem is not virtuality. It is the incentive structure of the medium through which group identity is formed.

A platform optimized for engagement has reason to discover which signals keep members emotionally activated. Outrage, humiliation, fear, triumph, scandal, and enemy surveillance are efficient. A group can therefore be trained to experience itself

through conflict. Members return not mainly to build something together but to observe what the other side has done. The enemy becomes the community's most reliable content producer.

This is a degraded form of belonging because it requires almost no common work. Traditional communities imposed costs: showing up, caring for the sick, repairing a building, learning a craft, contributing money, tolerating difficult personalities, raising children, maintaining ceremonies. Synthetic tribes can offer the emotional reward of solidarity with very little obligation beyond signaling. The member feels enlisted without necessarily becoming useful to anyone.

One response would be to condemn these communities as fake. A better response is to ask what they reveal about unmet demand. People want institutions in which contribution is visible, memory persists, competence matters, and membership changes what they are expected to do. Many contemporary institutions offer either bureaucracy or consumption. The synthetic tribe wins partly because it offers drama.

Incomplete tribes should offer something better than drama: a project. A group organized only around identity is vulnerable to purity spirals because the main available action is defining membership. A group organized around building, learning, caring, discovering, practicing, or preserving has an external object against which internal claims can be tested. The bridge either stands or does not. The patient improves or does not. The theorem follows or does not. The garden survives or does not. Reality becomes a partial antidote to performative belonging.

This suggests a design principle: every healthy tribe should face outward toward a task, a craft, a service, a place, a body of knowledge, or a form of care that exists independently of the group's self-description. Identity should emerge partly from doing, not only from declaring.

Chapter 8 — Why Good Ideals Rot

The corruption of an ideal is often less mysterious than its defenders want it to be.

Groups begin with stories about purpose and gradually acquire stories about survival. At first the institution exists to produce something beyond itself: truth, worship, education, justice, mutual aid, public service, art, security, a product. Later, budgets, careers, status structures, property, offices, and reputations accumulate. Survival becomes a condition of pursuing the mission. Eventually the condition can replace the mission.

This transformation does not require villains. An employee who protects a department may sincerely believe the department is indispensable. A leader who suppresses criticism may genuinely fear that public disagreement will destroy a fragile institution. Members who defend a failed practice may remember the historical struggle that created it. Organizational self-interest is powerful precisely because it can speak in the language of the founding ideal.

Three mechanisms are especially corrosive. The first is monopoly over interpretation: the group decides not only what its ideal is but what counts as evidence that the ideal is working. The second is concentration of exit costs: leaving means losing too much. The third is moral asymmetry: failures by insiders are treated as mistakes while failures by outsiders are treated as revelations of character. Once these mechanisms align, correction becomes difficult even when everyone believes in correction abstractly.

Norm enforcement illustrates the ambiguity. Experimental work on cooperation, including research by Fehr and Gächter, shows that people are often willing to incur costs to punish free riders. This capacity can sustain cooperation where selfish calculation would predict defection. But the same appetite for enforcement

can become persecution when norms are bad, accusations are cheap, or punishment confers status. The question is not whether a group has sanctions. Every serious group does. The question is whether sanctions themselves are governable.

Ostrom's work on durable commons is useful because it resists both romantic spontaneity and centralized pessimism. Communities can govern shared resources, but robust systems tend to possess recognizable institutional features: meaningful boundaries, locally appropriate rules, participation in rule-making, monitoring, graduated sanctions, accessible conflict resolution, and nested layers of governance. The broader lesson is not a universal template. It is that cooperation requires designed feedback.

Ideals rot when feedback becomes disloyalty. In science, replication and criticism are not insults to truth; they are procedures by which attachment to truth is distinguished from attachment to a theory. The same logic can be generalized. A community that cannot name the observations that would make it revise a rule has stopped governing itself and begun protecting an identity.

This is why institutional humility must be procedural rather than rhetorical. A constitution that says 'we may be wrong' is pleasant. A constitution that gives dissenters standing, records decisions, rotates authority, protects exit, permits external audit, and defines how a rule can be amended is more serious. Humility becomes real only when someone can use it against the current leadership.

An incomplete tribe is not incorruptible. Nothing human is. Its advantage is more modest: corruption in one domain need not capture the person's entire social world, and the group's own architecture contains places from which correction can begin.

Part Iii — Incomplete Tribes

Belong deeply. Rule partially. Leave room for another world.

Chapter 9 — The Principle of Incompleteness

A healthy community should be strong enough to shape a life and limited enough not to own it.

The central proposal can now be stated more precisely. An incomplete tribe is a bounded community that cultivates thick cooperation while formally and culturally renouncing total jurisdiction over its members and total moral authority over outsiders. Its incompleteness is not a defect to be repaired. It is a constitutional property.

The first form is epistemic incompleteness. The group assumes that some of its important beliefs may be wrong. This does not mean treating every proposition as equally doubtful. A laboratory can be highly confident in a result; a religious community can maintain doctrine; a professional body can enforce standards. Epistemic incompleteness means that no belief becomes true merely because the group needs it to be true. There must remain procedures by which reality can embarrass identity.

The second is jurisdictional incompleteness. The group defines what it may legitimately ask of members. A chess club may govern tournament conduct but not romantic life. An employer may govern the use of company systems but should need exceptional justification to govern political friendships. A scientific association may set methodological standards without claiming authority over every moral question. Boundaries are not signs of weak values. They are defenses against institutional appetite.

The third is identity incompleteness. Members are expected to belong elsewhere. This principle is stronger than tolerating outside interests. A resilient tribe should regard some external attachments as beneficial because they keep the group from becoming

the sole provider of truth, status, affection, and material security. The member who brings another vocabulary into the room can be inconvenient. That inconvenience is part of the safety mechanism.

The fourth is moral incompleteness. Outsiders are not presumed inferior because they are outsiders. The group may believe its practices are better for particular purposes. A research team should be allowed to think its method superior to a rival method. A community may defend a demanding ethic. Moral incompleteness simply prevents local superiority from becoming total human superiority. The rival can be wrong about an important thing without becoming a lesser person.

The fifth is temporal incompleteness. The group is not the end of history. Its rules contain an amendment path; its leadership is replaceable; its founding story is not immune to archival correction; its mission can be completed or rendered obsolete. Some institutions should have the courage to die. An organization that survives every possible failure has probably made survival its real purpose.

These forms of incompleteness reinforce one another. Multiple identities make epistemic correction easier because dissenters retain external support. Limited jurisdiction lowers the cost of disagreement. Moral recognition of outsiders makes external criticism more audible. Revisability allows institutions to change without describing change as betrayal.

None of this implies softness. Incomplete tribes may enforce demanding internal norms. A mountaineering team cannot treat safety discipline as optional pluralism. A cryptographic protocol cannot compromise with arithmetic. A hospital cannot allow each practitioner to improvise sterile procedure. Strong local rules are compatible with limited jurisdiction because the justification comes from the task and remains bounded by it.

The principle can be summarized in one sentence: make belonging deep, but keep sovereignty divided. The tribe should be able to say 'this is what we do here' without being able to say 'this is all that you are.'

Chapter 10 — Overlapping Loyalties

Civilization may depend less on making groups love one another than on making people impossible to divide cleanly.

A society becomes dangerous when its social boundaries align. Imagine two populations that live in different neighborhoods, attend different schools, consume different media, work in different professions, worship separately, marry internally, vote differently, and tell incompatible histories. Any disagreement can activate the entire stack. Economic conflict becomes cultural conflict; cultural conflict becomes moral conflict; moral conflict becomes existential conflict.

Now imagine the opposite pattern. People still disagree, sometimes fiercely, but the lines cross. Political rivals share professions. Religious differences cut across economic classes. Neighbors belong to different ideological groups but the same sports club. Engineers from competing firms contribute to the same technical standard. Families contain multiple worldviews. A person cannot accept a simple map in which all virtue lies on one side because too many people she loves would fall on the other.

This is the political importance of overlapping loyalties. Research on intergroup conflict has repeatedly found that multiple identities can alter how people react to conflict. The effect should not be romanticized; people can prioritize one identity and suppress the rest. But cross-cutting attachments create alternative pathways for interpretation and negotiation. They complicate mobilization.

Complication is often treated as a problem in political communication. Leaders want clear constituencies. Movements want coherent messages. Algorithms want predictable categories. Yet from the perspective of peace, ambiguity can be a public good. A citizen who is difficult to classify is also difficult to conscript into total hatred.

This suggests a different measure of social health. Instead of asking only how diverse a society is, ask how its differences are correlated. Diversity can coexist with segregation if every dimension of difference stacks in the same direction. Conversely, a society may contain strong local identities while remaining resilient if those identities intersect in many combinations. The geometry matters more than the count.

Institutions can encourage this geometry. Schools, professional associations, public service, shared infrastructure, scientific collaborations, local clubs, federated online communities, and cross-border projects can create relations that do not mirror political divisions. The point is not forced harmony. It is to generate enough independent edges in the social graph that no single cleavage can cut the network in two.

There is a cost. Overlapping loyalty creates internal conflict. The member must sometimes disappoint one group to remain faithful to another. A physician may resist a political demand because of professional ethics. A scientist may reject a conclusion preferred by friends. A family member may defend an outsider. These moments are painful precisely because the identities are real.

But a civilization in which nobody experiences divided loyalty may be one in which the divisions have already become too perfect. The discomfort of multiple belonging is one of the prices of peace.

Chapter 11 — Exit, Dissent, and the Right Not to Be Whole

A community that cannot survive voluntary departure is not asking for loyalty; it is asking for captivity.

Exit is often treated as the opposite of commitment. If members can leave, the argument goes, why would they sacrifice for the group? Some degree of stickiness is indeed necessary. A team cannot function if every inconvenience triggers departure. Families, research programs, companies, and civic associations all depend on people remaining through periods of frustration. A culture of instant exit produces shallow institutions.

Yet impossible exit produces a more dangerous shallowness: public conformity without internal consent. Members learn to perform loyalty. Leaders mistake silence for agreement. Problems become visible only when they are catastrophic because everyone with early information had too much to lose by speaking or leaving.

The relevant distinction is between costly exit and annihilating exit. Leaving a serious community may properly involve costs: unfinished work, lost status, sadness, the need to rebuild routines. What it should not require is losing one's entire social network, legal identity, livelihood, access to children, physical safety, or the right to narrate one's own experience. When all these goods are bundled, the group acquires coercive power regardless of whether formal membership is technically voluntary.

Dissent performs a related function. A healthy group should distinguish disagreement about means, disagreement about facts, disagreement about peripheral values, and rejection of the group's defining purpose. Not every disagreement can be absorbed. A pa-

cifist association need not appoint a chair whose mission is to promote war. But if every empirical correction is treated as rejection of purpose, the group will lose contact with reality.

This requires what might be called constitutional heresy: protected ways to challenge current interpretation without automatically renouncing membership. Science institutionalizes a version of this through criticism and replication. Courts institutionalize it through appeals. Software communities use issue trackers, competing implementations, and forks. Religious traditions often possess their own long histories of commentary and schism. The specific mechanism varies; the need does not.

Forking is particularly interesting in the digital age. It allows a community to divide without requiring one side to destroy the other. But easy forking can also fragment effort endlessly. The goal is not maximal splintering. It is credible exit: the knowledge that leadership does not possess absolute control because members retain some capacity to continue the project elsewhere.

Exit also disciplines the tribe's claim on identity. If former members must be demonized, the group is admitting that its story depends on preventing comparison. A mature community should be capable of saying: this person left us, perhaps for reasons we reject, and remains a person rather than a traitor archetype.

The right not to be whole is therefore the right to contain unresolved affiliations. I may belong without merging. I may love a community and refuse one of its beliefs. I may inherit a tradition and revise it. I may leave and still retain gratitude. Incomplete tribes make room for these sentences because they do not equate coherence with totality.

Chapter 12 — Cooperation Among the Imperfect

Trust should be cultivated, but systems should not require infinite trust to function.

A common mistake in community design is to choose between trust and rules. High-trust communities are praised as organic; rule-bound institutions are criticized as bureaucratic. In reality, trust and rules are complements. Rules make trust less reckless, while trust prevents rules from becoming infinitely expensive to specify and enforce.

Research on cooperation helps explain why. People often behave as conditional cooperators: they are willing to contribute when they believe others will contribute and when free riding is not rewarded indefinitely. Norms, reputation, communication, and sanctioning can sustain collective action. But each mechanism has failure modes. Reputation can become gossip. Monitoring can become surveillance. Sanctions can become vendettas. Shared norms can become conformity. The institutional problem is not to find the pure mechanism; it is to balance mechanisms that correct one another.

Ostrom's empirical work is valuable here because it focused on communities managing real resources over long periods. Durable arrangements often connected clear boundaries with local rule-making, monitoring, graduated sanctions, conflict-resolution mechanisms, and nested governance. The word graduated deserves attention. A system that responds to every violation with maximum punishment turns ordinary error into existential conflict. A system that never punishes teaches members that cooperation is for fools.

Incomplete tribes need a ladder of response. Misunderstanding should be corrected differently from negligence; negligence differently from opportunism; opportunism differently from predation.

The ability to distinguish these categories is one reason small and medium communities can sometimes govern behavior more intelligently than anonymous centralized systems. They possess context. But context also creates favoritism, which is why external appeal or audit may be necessary.

Transparency should likewise be selective. Total transparency sounds morally attractive until one imagines living inside it. People need private spaces to change their minds, forgive, experiment, and recover from embarrassment. What must be transparent are the decisions and resource flows that affect others significantly: authority, money, sanctions, rule changes, conflicts of interest. The person need not be transparent; power should be.

Leadership is unavoidable. Even communities that reject formal hierarchy usually develop informal authorities based on competence, charisma, seniority, money, network centrality, or control of information. Unnamed power is not necessarily less powerful. The safer strategy is to make authority legible, bounded, reviewable, and replaceable. A group should know who can decide what, for how long, and under what appeal.

Ritual also matters more than rationalists often admit. Repeated practices transform abstract values into expectations. A weekly review, a communal meal, a public acknowledgment of error, a ceremony of admission, a tradition of thanking departing members, a norm that the most senior person speaks last: these can shape behavior more effectively than mission statements. Ritual is social memory encoded in action.

The incomplete tribe is therefore not a loose network of agreeable individuals. It is an institution with boundaries, rules, sanctions, symbols, history, and leadership. Its distinctiveness lies in the fact that each of these powers is paired with a limit. It trusts, but veri-

fies. It demands, but not everything. It remembers, but permits correction. It punishes, but proportionally. It belongs to its members without claiming to possess them.

Part Iv — A Civilization Of Incomplete Tribes

Belong deeply. Rule partially. Leave room for another world.

Chapter 13 — Polycentric Civilization

The alternative to one sovereign center is not chaos; it can be an order made from many centers that constrain and support one another.

If incomplete tribes are desirable at small scale, what kind of civilization can contain them? The answer cannot be a simple multiplication of autonomous enclaves. Groups affect outsiders. Rivers cross borders. Epidemics travel. Markets connect strangers. Carbon accumulates globally. Weapons do not respect local sovereignty. Children born inside a community did not choose its rules. Some goods and risks are irreducibly shared.

The more promising model is polycentric: many centers of decision-making with partially overlapping jurisdictions, connected by rules for coordination and appeal. Elinor Ostrom used polycentricity to describe systems in which multiple authorities operate at different scales rather than assuming every problem must be solved either by a centralized state or by atomized private actors. The concept is useful far beyond resource management.

A polycentric civilization asks first at what scale a problem becomes real. Neighborhood noise can be governed locally. A river basin may require regional coordination. Product safety may require national or transnational standards. Climate and certain technological risks require global mechanisms. The principle is not that smaller is always better. It is that authority should not migrate upward merely because upward authority exists.

This arrangement protects diversity by permitting local experimentation. Different communities can test different rules and learn from one another. Failure can remain bounded. Success can spread by imitation rather than conquest. A single universal policy may achieve consistency but can also universalize error. Multiple centers create redundancy.

Redundancy is an underrated civilizational virtue. Engineers distrust systems with one component whose failure destroys everything. Societies should be similarly suspicious. Independent courts, universities, municipalities, professional bodies, markets, civil associations, families, standards organizations, media, and transnational networks can each become corrupt or foolish. Their partial independence prevents any one corruption from automatically becoming total.

Polycentricity also creates interfaces where tribes meet. These interfaces need their own culture: contract, due process, translation, evidence, reciprocal recognition, arbitration, interoperable standards. The language here is deliberately procedural. The purpose of the interface is not to make the communities identical. It is to let them cooperate without requiring conversion.

The danger, of course, is unequal power. A wealthy tribe can dominate a poor one while formally respecting its autonomy. A company can make 'voluntary' terms unavoidable. A local community can violate the rights of members who lack credible exit. Polycentricity therefore requires a moral and legal floor beneath local variation. Incompleteness applies upward too: local autonomy is not absolute sovereignty.

One can imagine civilization as an ecology rather than a pyramid. Some institutions are ancient trees, some temporary crops, some fungi connecting roots underground. People move among them. Resources and ideas circulate. No single organism is the forest, yet the forest is not merely a collection of isolated organisms. Its stability comes partly from diversity, partly from constraint, and partly from relations that no central planner designed in full.

The political beauty of such an order is modest. It does not promise final harmony. It promises that disagreement can remain distributed. In a world of powerful technology, distribution of failure may be one of the highest forms of wisdom available to us.

Chapter 14 — Conflict Without Extermination

The goal is not a world without enemies. It is a world in which enmity does not automatically grant permission for erasure.

Conflict is sometimes a sign that a social order is alive. Workers and employers have different interests. Generations disagree about inheritance. Scientific schools compete. Regions want different policies. Moral communities defend incompatible practices. Attempts to erase such conflict can simply push it underground, where it returns as conspiracy, sabotage, or sudden rupture.

Civilization should therefore be judged partly by its repertoire of conflict. How many ways can people say no? How many ways can they resist, bargain, secede, appeal, criticize, boycott, compete, litigate, vote, fork, ridicule, refuse, and organize without turning to physical destruction? A rich repertoire lowers the pressure on any single channel.

The concept of a loyal opposition is one of the strangest and most important inventions in political life: an opponent can seek to replace those in power without being defined as an enemy of the community itself. The same idea has analogues elsewhere. A scientific critic can attack a theory while remaining part of the field. A union can fight management while both remain invested in the survival of the enterprise. A faction can lose a vote and continue participating tomorrow.

For this to work, losers require guarantees. They need reason to believe that today's defeat will not eliminate tomorrow's opportunity. Winners require restraint: the ability to distinguish victory from permission to restructure the entire game. Both sides need memory of occasions on which roles reversed. Repeated interaction is civilizing because it makes absolute exploitation expensive.

Incomplete tribes can contribute by refusing to translate every external conflict into internal purity tests. Members may cooperate with outsiders for limited purposes without being accused of contamination. Negotiators may return from compromise without being treated as traitors. The group can maintain red lines while allowing representatives to explore the space between red lines.

There is also a role for deliberate asymmetry between rhetoric and capability. Institutions should be designed for the possibility that people will occasionally speak irresponsibly, become angry, or elect poor leaders without giving every moment of passion immediate access to irreversible destructive power. Cooling periods, multiple signatures, judicial review, distributed command, and verification procedures are all ways of placing time between impulse and catastrophe.

At the international level, this logic becomes stark. Adversarial states do not need mutual affection to maintain hotlines, inspection regimes, incident protocols, arms-control agreements, and norms around catastrophic technologies. Such mechanisms are sometimes dismissed as weak because they do not abolish rivalry. Their weakness is their purpose. They keep one domain of cooperation alive when others fail.

The architecture of incomplete tribes therefore scales into a philosophy of constrained enmity. We should assume that serious enemies will sometimes exist. The civilizational question is how many bridges remain intact while they do.

Chapter 15 — AI, Abundance, and the New Tribal Machinery

Technology does not replace the ancient human problem. It changes its speed, scale, and cost.

Artificial intelligence is often discussed as if its primary social effect will be economic: productivity, employment, automation, new industries. Those effects matter, but there is another possibility. AI may become machinery for manufacturing social worlds. It can generate persuasive narratives, personalized explanations, synthetic media, community rituals, moderation decisions, reputational summaries, and endless responsive conversation. It can help groups remember, coordinate, recruit, teach, and defend themselves.

This could strengthen small communities in constructive ways. A group with little money could maintain archives, translate materials, teach newcomers, mediate disputes, document decisions, manage shared resources, and connect members across languages. Local institutions that currently depend on exhausted volunteers might gain administrative capacity. AI could lower the cost of being a serious small institution.

The darker mirror is obvious. The same systems can create personalized propaganda, automate enemy monitoring, generate plausible accusations, simulate consensus, and maintain members in an information environment optimized for loyalty. A complete tribe once needed a bureaucracy. A future complete tribe may need only a sufficiently capable model, a data store, and control over the interfaces through which members experience the world.

Personalization intensifies the danger because every member can receive a different justification for the same group narrative. One person is persuaded through fear, another through moral aspira-

tion, another through technical arguments, another through belonging. The doctrine no longer needs to be coherent in public. It needs only to be effective in private. This is a new form of ideological scalability.

Yet AI can also support incompleteness if designed to preserve provenance, disagreement, external references, and alternative interpretations. A community's assistant could be required to distinguish group doctrine from contested evidence, show where a claim came from, preserve minority reports, expose members to strong versions of outside criticism, and record when rules changed. It could make institutional memory harder to rewrite.

The decisive question is who governs the model's objective. If the goal is engagement, retention, conversion, or loyalty, the system may discover that epistemic friction is bad for the metric. If the goal includes corrigibility, plural sources, and member autonomy, the interface will behave differently. We should expect no accidental alignment here. The machinery will optimize what we reward.

Abundance itself may make tribes more important. If AI cheapens many forms of production, the scarce goods may increasingly be trusted selection, shared purpose, reputation, embodied experience, scarce attention, and credible human commitment. People may join communities not primarily to access information but to know which information is worth caring about and with whom they want to act on it.

This makes the design of communities a technological problem as well as a social one. The future internet could become an archipelago of interoperable, self-governing groups whose tools help them cooperate while preserving external windows. Or it could become a collection of perfectly personalized realities, each internally coherent and mutually unintelligible. Both futures are technically plausible.

The principle of incompleteness offers a design criterion. No AI should become the sole interpreter of a member's world. No community model should control all memory without audit. No personalization system should make external comparison prohibitively difficult. The more intimate the machine becomes, the more important it is that somewhere else remains visible.

Chapter 16 — Hope Without Innocence

Hope becomes credible when it stops requiring us to forget what human beings are capable of.

The question with which we began can now be answered, although not conclusively. Are human beings condemned to cycles of peace and war until one cycle ends everything? There is no evidence that history contains a mechanism guaranteeing our survival. There is also no evidence that violence returns at a biologically fixed interval regardless of institutions. The future is neither secured nor sentenced.

A mature hope begins by giving up inevitability. Progress can be reversed. Institutions can decay. Knowledge can be lost. Technologies can increase the consequences of ordinary stupidity. Peace does not become permanent merely because a generation experiences it as normal. A civilization capable of destroying itself has to treat maintenance as a first-order activity.

But maintenance is not the same as stagnation. Incomplete tribes create places for experimentation. Some will fail because their ideals are incoherent. Some will become authoritarian and lose members. Some will discover practices worth copying. A polycentric order can learn through variation if failures remain bounded and information about them remains available.

This may be a more realistic source of improvement than the dream of universal conversion. We do not need one philosophy to conquer the world. We need many communities to become laboratories of decent life while a shared floor prevents their experiments from consuming unwilling subjects. The unit of progress becomes the transferable practice rather than the victorious ideology.

Such a civilization would still contain tragedy. People would betray groups that deserved loyalty. Groups would reject members they should have kept. Some communities would disappear. Inequality would persist in new forms. Love would remain unfair. Status would still wound. No institutional design abolishes mortality, jealousy, ambition, or the fact that two legitimate goods can conflict.

The promise is smaller: these contradictions need not all align. A person can lose one community and remain held by another. A society can make one political mistake while independent institutions resist it. A scientific consensus can be wrong while dissent survives somewhere. A technological system can fail without taking every system down with it. Resilience is the political form of humility.

Perhaps this is what idealism looks like after innocence. It does not expect the final victory of good people. It expects recurring work by mixed people inside revisable institutions. It replaces the dream of purity with the practice of correction. It treats peace not as proof of human goodness but as an achievement worth engineering again and again.

And it allows us to recover a sentence that cynicism made embarrassing: a better world is possible. Not because we will become another species, but because we can become better architects of the conditions under which this species meets itself.

Epilogue — The Archipelago

We may not need one final shore. We may need enough bridges that no island becomes the whole world.

Imagine civilization not as a pyramid but as an archipelago. The islands are communities of different density and purpose: families, cities, research groups, professions, faiths, companies, schools, artistic circles, digital collectives, nations, temporary expeditions. Some are inherited; some chosen. Some last centuries; some last a season. Their internal cultures differ. They are not equally admirable.

Between them run bridges of different strength: law, trade, friendship, intermarriage, standards, science, travel, translation, treaties, shared infrastructure, emergency assistance, and the simple recognition that an outsider is still a person. No bridge must carry everything. Some carry only data. Some carry goods. Some carry people. Some carry appeals. The failure of one bridge does not require all others to collapse.

A healthy person in this world is not homeless between communities. Nor is she dissolved into one. She may be deeply loyal and still divided. Her identities may sometimes argue inside her. That argument is not a psychological defect. It is evidence that no institution has acquired monopoly over conscience.

A healthy tribe in this world possesses memory without mythology, confidence without omniscience, boundaries without dehumanization, rituals without total control, leadership without ownership, and ideals without the fantasy that history ends at its gates. It knows what it is for. It also knows what it is not for.

The human problem remains. We will still form coalitions, desire recognition, fear outsiders, compete, imitate, love selectively, misjudge motives, and tell stories in which we look better than we were. Nothing in this book eliminates those tendencies. The proposal is to stop building social systems that require their elimination.

The great danger of our century may be the combination of ancient coalition psychology with technologies of unprecedented reach. The corresponding opportunity is that we now understand enough about institutions, networks, incentives, cognition, and computation to design more deliberately. We can make communities easier to form without making them total. We can make memory durable without making it immutable. We can make coordination powerful without concentrating every form of power in one place.

The incomplete tribe is not a destination. It is a constraint on destinations. Wherever we build, something must remain outside: another authority, another friendship, another archive, another explanation, another place to go, another group capable of telling us that we have become absurd.

That incompleteness may feel unsatisfying to the part of us that wants the final answer. It is nevertheless possible that civilization depends on never receiving one.

Notes — Evidence and Further Reading

This is an essay rather than a literature review. The references below identify the main empirical and theoretical sources behind claims about social identity, intergroup contact, cooperation, governance, network scale, conflict, and technological risk. Several claims remain matters of active scholarly debate; the text intentionally distinguishes design proposals from empirical findings.

Tajfel, H., Billig, M. G., Bundy, R. P., & Flament, C. (1971). “Social categorization and intergroup behaviour.” European Journal of Social Psychology, 1(2), 149–178. DOI: 10.1002/ejsp.2420010202. Link

Brewer, M. B. (1999). “The psychology of prejudice: Ingroup love or outgroup hate?” Journal of Social Issues, 55(3), 429–444. A useful distinction between favoritism toward one’s own group and active hostility toward outsiders. Link

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Fehr, E., & Gächter, S. (2002). “Altruistic punishment in humans.” Nature, 415, 137–140. DOI: 10.1038/415137a. An influential experimental demonstration that people may pay costs to punish free riders. Link

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Ostrom, E. (1990). Governing the Commons: The Evolution of Institutions for Collective Action. Cambridge University Press. See also Ostrom’s 2009 Nobel Prize lecture and Nobel material on long-enduring self-governed commons. Link

Henrich, J., Heine, S. J., & Norenzayan, A. (2010). “The weirdest people in the world?” Behavioral and Brain Sciences, 33(2–3), 61–83. DOI: 10.1017/S0140525X0999152X. A major warning against treating findings from narrow cultural samples as universal human psychology. Link

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Elster, A. et al. (2012). “Group Identities,” in The Oxford Handbook of Intergroup Conflict. The chapter reviews evidence that awareness of multiple identities can mitigate some reactions associated with intergroup conflict. Link

Uppsala Conflict Data Program (UCDP), conflict datasets; processed and visualized by Our World in Data. Current series consulted in September 2026. These data support the book’s deliberately non-teleological claim: conflict levels change substantially over time, and recent increases coexist with lower levels than some twentieth-century peaks. Link

Bulletin of the Atomic Scientists. 2026 Doomsday Clock Statement. The Clock is a risk-communication metaphor, not a probabilistic forecast; the book cites it only as an indicator of expert concern about interacting technological and geopolitical risks. Link

Berlin, I. (1958). “Two Concepts of Liberty.” A classic argument for taking value pluralism seriously rather than assuming all genuine human goods can be harmonized without loss. Link

Popper, K. R. (1945). The Open Society and Its Enemies. Relevant here less as a political program than for the principle that institutions should make bad rulers and bad decisions removable without catastrophe. Link